The *AI Shelf* Playbook

What ChatGPT, Perplexity and Google AI look for before they recommend a product, and what your store can do about it.

By Kelian van Tulder

Founder, Produkto

INTRODUCTION

Your products are on a *new shelf*

More shoppers now ask an AI assistant what to buy. It reads the web, then names a few products. If yours isn't one of them, that shopper never sees it, and nothing in your analytics tells you it happened.

This playbook is what you can control. It's seven cheat sheets, each with a page on how to use it and one thing to do this week. Start wherever your store is weakest. The scorecard at the end shows you where that is.

> A playbook, not a promise. It lists the work; it can't guarantee an AI will pick a product. What it will do is make sure you've given it every reason to.

INSIDE

1. Shopping before AI vs after AI — What changed
2. “ChatGPT doesn't send us any sales” — Why you can't see it
3. Google Shopping vs ChatGPT vs Perplexity — Where shoppers ask
4. 6 Layers Of AI Shopping — What to do, in order
5. The SHELF Framework — The method
6. How To Master AI Shopping — One product, start to finish
7. The AI Shopping Funnel — The whole picture
8. Scorecard: is your store AI-ready? — Score yourself

WHAT CHANGED

Shopping before AI vs after AI

1

A shopper used to search, open ten tabs, compare and pick. Now more of them ask an AI assistant once and get a few names back. The work of getting picked didn't disappear. It moved, and it grew.

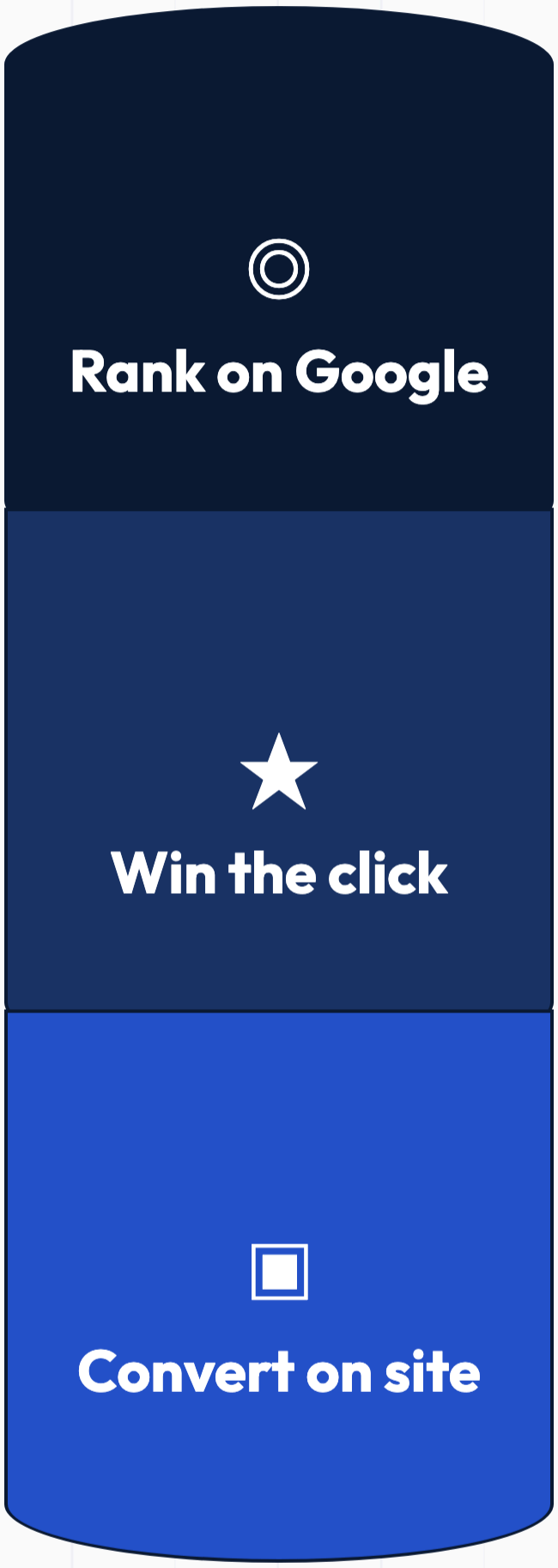
WHAT TO TAKE FROM IT

- Ranking on Google still matters. It's the foundation, not the finish line.
- AI needs three things from you: to find your product, to understand what it's for, and to trust it.
- Each of those is a separate job. Most stores have done one.

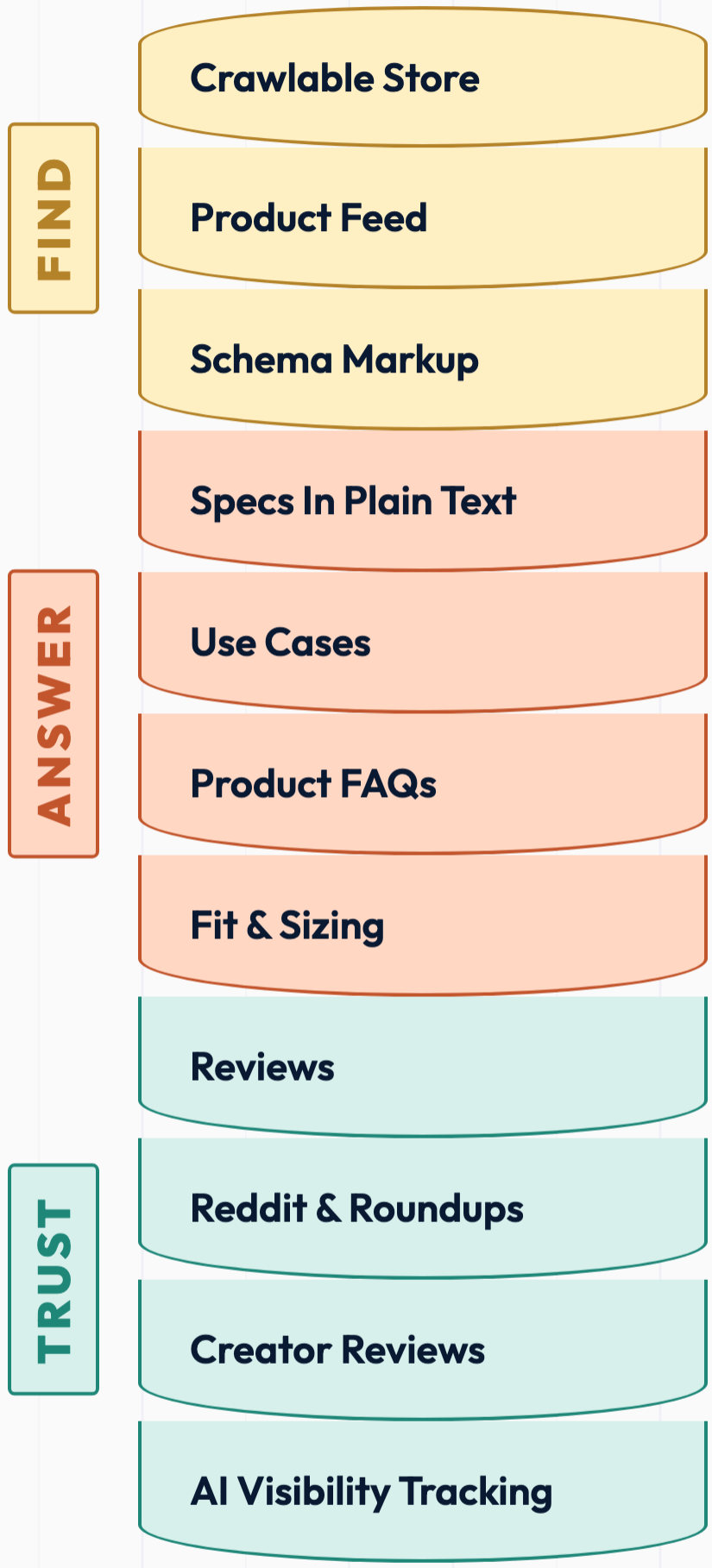
> **Do this week:** Read the right-hand stack and tick each layer you've actually worked on in the last 6 months.

The sheet is on the next page →

Shopping *Before AI*



Shopping *After AI*



See which of your products AI recommends, free
Comment "CHECK"

WHY YOU CAN'T SEE IT

“ChatGPT doesn't send us any sales”

2

Most of the AI part of a purchase happens where your analytics can't see it. The shopper asks, reads, compares, comes back later and buys. Your dashboard logs it as “direct” or as the last ad they clicked.

WHAT TO TAKE FROM IT

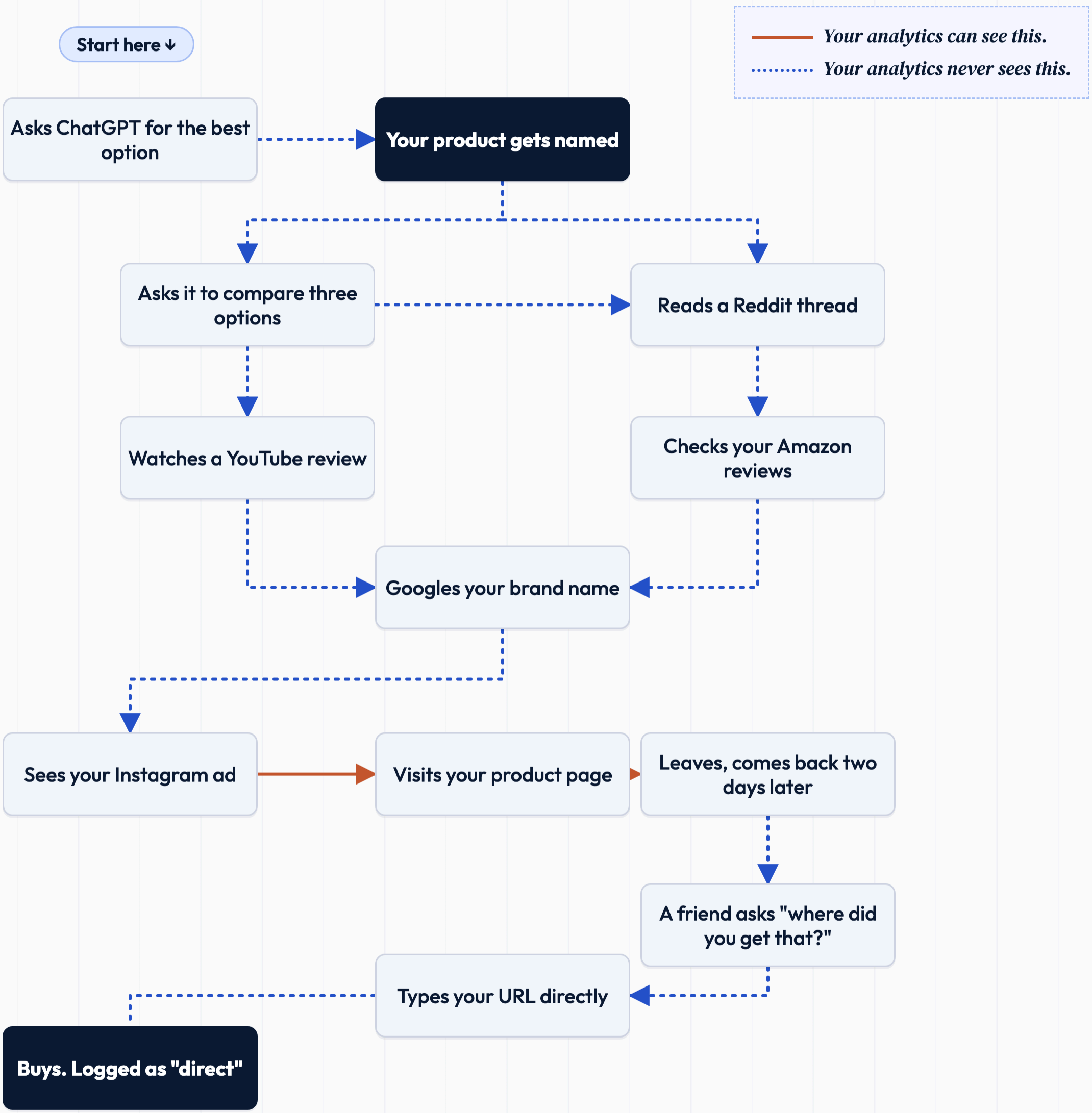
- Low AI referral traffic doesn't mean AI isn't involved.
- The only way to know if AI names your products is to ask it the way a buyer would.
- Ask about your products and your category, never just your brand name.

Do this week: Ask your customers “how did you first hear about us?” at checkout, and add “ChatGPT or another AI” as an option.

The sheet is on the next page →

"ChatGPT doesn't send us any sales"

THE REALITY:



See whether AI names your products, free — **Comment "CHECK"**

WHERE SHOPPERS ASK

Google Shopping vs ChatGPT vs Perplexity

3

Each assistant finds and picks products differently. Google leans on your product feed. ChatGPT reads the web and reviews. Perplexity shows its sources, which tells you exactly where to be mentioned.

WHAT TO TAKE FROM IT

- You don't need a different strategy for each one. You need the same product facts, stated clearly, everywhere.
- Use Perplexity's sources as your to-do list: those are the pages it trusts in your category.
- Track which products each one names, for which questions.

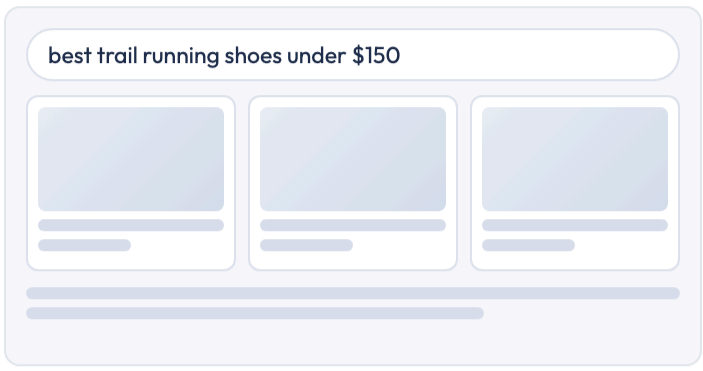
Do this week: Ask all three the same buyer question about your best seller. Write down every product named.

The sheet is on the next page →

HOW TO GET YOUR PRODUCTS FOUND IN:

Google Shopping *vs* ChatGPT *vs* Perplexity

Google Shopping



Google Shopping = getting your products into Google's product listings, AI Overviews and AI Mode

HOW IT WORKS:

- Reads your Merchant Center feed and your product pages
- Matches products to the search, filtered by price and stock

PROS:

- Huge existing demand
- Free listings alongside the ads

CONS:

- Crowded with ads and price competition
- Messy feed data gets you filtered out

HOW TO RANK HIGHER:

- Complete feed: GTIN, price, stock, size, color
- Product structured data that matches the feed
- Reviews on the product page

WHAT TO TRACK:

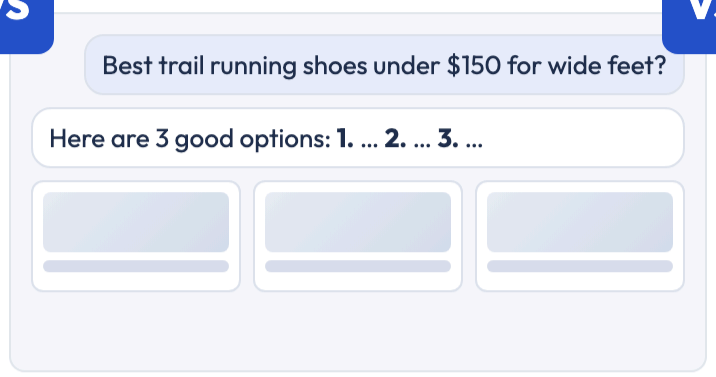
- Impressions and clicks in Merchant Center

POWER MOVE:

- Fix the feed data on your top 10 products before adding anything new

VS

ChatGPT



ChatGPT = getting your product named when a shopper asks ChatGPT what to buy

HOW IT WORKS:

- Searches the web for the question, reads pages and reviews
- Names a few products, often with product cards

PROS:

- Shoppers arrive having already decided
- Only a few products get named, so a pick stands out

CONS:

- No ranking report: you only know if you ask
- Answers change from one ask to the next

HOW TO RANK HIGHER:

- Answer buyer questions in plain text on the page
- Get mentioned in reviews, Reddit and roundups
- Don't block OAI-SearchBot in robots.txt

WHAT TO TRACK:

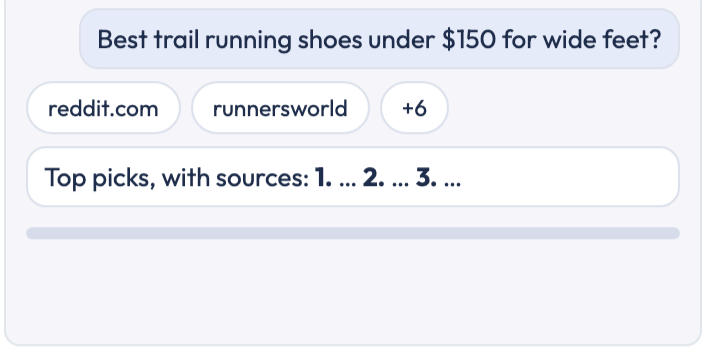
- Which of your products it names, for which questions

POWER MOVE:

- Ask it your buyer's question, open the winner's page, add what it states that yours doesn't

VS

Perplexity



Perplexity = getting your product named, and your pages cited as a source

HOW IT WORKS:

- Searches the web live for every question
- Shows the sources it used next to the answer

PROS:

- You can see exactly which sources it trusts
- Win those sources and you win the answer

CONS:

- Smaller audience than Google
- Sources shift as new content appears

HOW TO RANK HIGHER:

- Get into the articles it already cites
- Clear specs it can quote word for word
- Don't block PerplexityBot in robots.txt

WHAT TO TRACK:

- Which sources it cites when it names a rival

POWER MOVE:

- Find the article it cites most for your category and get your product into it

See which of your products each one recommends, free — **Comment "CHECK"**

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WHAT TO DO, IN ORDER

6 Layers Of AI Shopping

Start at the top. Each layer depends on the one above it: if AI can't read your store, nothing below it counts.

WHAT TO TAKE FROM IT

- Layers 1 and 2 are technical and usually quick to fix.
- Layer 3, answering the buyer's question on the page, is where most stores have the biggest gap.
- Layers 4 and 5 are earned off your site, and take longest.

Do this week: Open your robots.txt today and make sure it doesn't block OAI-SearchBot or PerplexityBot.

The sheet is on the next page →

6 Layers Of *AI Shopping*

Start Here

1 Make sure AI can actually read your store.

If OAI-SearchBot, PerplexityBot and Googlebot can't read your product pages, nothing below this layer exists. It's the one that breaks most, and the cheapest to fix.

- OAI-SearchBot
- PerplexityBot
- Googlebot
- robots.txt
- Raw HTML
- Text, Not Images
- Variant Pages

2 Describe each product the same way everywhere.

Your product page, Google Merchant Center, Amazon and your feed need to agree. Three different titles and prices, and you've built three weak products.

- Product Titles
- Merchant Center
- Product Feed
- Amazon Listing
- Schema Markup
- GTIN
- Price Match

3 Answer the buyer's question on the page.

Shoppers ask with a size, a material, a price and a use case in the question. "Premium quality" answers none of them. State each one in plain text.

- Size & Fit
- Materials
- Use Case
- Who It's For
- Who It's Not For
- Specs Table
- Product FAQs

4 Get mentioned where the models already look.

AI leans on reviews, Reddit threads, "best of" roundups and YouTube reviews. This layer isn't built on your store, it's built where buyers already talk.

- Reddit
- Review Sites
- "Best Of" Lists
- YouTube Reviews
- Gift Guides
- Creators
- Forums

5 Get named as the pick (not listed beneath it).

Being the recommendation takes proof a model can lift: reviews that name a use case, clear comparisons, real numbers. You earn this layer last.

- Use-Case Reviews
- Comparison Pages
- Review Volume
- Awards
- Real Numbers
- Named Use Cases
- Trust Signals

6 Give the shopper who already decided a reason to buy.

Shoppers who arrive from AI have usually decided already. Land them on a page that confirms the choice, not a homepage and a pop-up.

- Clear Price
- Stock Visible
- Shipping Time
- Returns
- Reviews Up Top
- Size Guide
- Fast Checkout

Finish Here

See which of your products AI recommends, free — Comment "CHECK"

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THE METHOD

The SHELF Framework

5

SHELF is the checklist we use when we look at a store: Structured, Helpful, Earned, Listed, Followed. It turns “get recommended by AI” into five jobs you can assign to someone.

WHAT TO TAKE FROM IT

- S and L are mostly one-off setup.
- H is page-by-page work, best done product by product, starting with best sellers.
- F is the habit: ask, note, fix, re-ask. Without it you never know if anything worked.

Do this week: Score your store 1–5 on each letter. Start with your lowest.

The sheet is on the next page →

The "SHELF" Framework

Use this sheet to get your products onto the AI shelf.

S STRUCTURED

1. Structured: make your store readable

Crawlers in
robots.txt allows OAI-SearchBot & PerplexityBot

→

Text, not images
Price, size, stock in the page text

→

Schema
Product markup that passes Google's test

→

Feed
Clean feed in Merchant Center

H HELPFUL

2. Helpful: answer the buyer's question on the page

1. **Who it's for:** state it in one line
2. **What it's for:** name the use case
3. **Materials & fit:** in words, not a pop-up
4. **Specs:** the numbers buyers compare
5. **Who it's not for:** builds trust
6. **FAQ:** the 3 questions asked before buying

E EARNED

3. Earned: get talked about where AI reads

Reviews
That name the use case, not just "love it"

Reddit
Real threads where your buyers ask

Roundups
"Best X for Y" articles and gift guides

Creators
YouTube and TikTok reviews

Press
Category features and comparisons

L LISTED

4. Listed: be in the places AI shops from

Google Merchant Center + ChatGPT shopping + Perplexity + Marketplaces =

More shelves to be picked from

Same title, price and specs on every one. If they disagree, AI trusts none of them.

F FOLLOWED

5. Followed: check it like you check your ads

Ask
Your buyer's questions, not your brand name

→

Note
Which products get named, and who beats you

→

Fix
Add what the winners state that you don't

→

Re-ask
Same questions, a few weeks later

Produkto runs step 5 for your whole catalog, every day

Comment "CHECK"

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ONE PRODUCT, START TO FINISH

How To Master AI Shopping

6

The fastest way to learn this is to do it once, properly, on one product. This sheet walks through a single best seller, from the buyer's question to the fixed page.

WHAT TO TAKE FROM IT

- Pick a product that sells well and has clear competitors.
- Use the category table to see what your page must state.
- Avoid the four mistakes at the bottom right. They're the most common ones.

Do this week: Block one afternoon this week and do the six steps on your best seller.

The sheet is on the next page →

How To Master *AI Shopping*

The shift that decides which of your products get recommended.

WHAT IS AI SHOPPING?

More shoppers skip the search results and ask an AI assistant what to buy. It reads the web, then names a few products. If yours isn't one of them, the shopper never sees it.

BEFORE AI
Search, open 10 tabs, compare, pick one. Your ad and your ranking get a look.

»»

WITH AI
Ask once, get 3 names, buy one. Only the 3 named products get a look.

Think of it this way: Google gave you a page of chances. AI gives you three.

HOW TO SET UP YOUR BEST SELLER

1. Write down the 3 questions buyers ask before buying it
2. Ask ChatGPT and Perplexity each question, the way a buyer would
3. Note every product they name, and the sources they cite
4. Open the winners' pages: list the facts they state that yours doesn't
5. Add those facts to your page in plain text, plus a short FAQ
6. Ask the same questions again in a few weeks and compare

EXAMPLE: 1 PRODUCT PAGE, ONE AFTERNOON

1. **Buyer asks:** "best dog harness for a puppy that pulls, under $40"
2. **AI names:** three harnesses. Yours isn't one
3. **Their pages state:** front clip, sizes by chest in inches, "for pullers"
4. **Yours states:** "comfy, durable, stylish"
5. **You add:** clip position, size chart, who it's for, an FAQ

Key rule: if a buyer would put it in the question, put it on the page.

ANATOMY OF A PAGE AI CAN RECOMMEND

Every product page AI can match has three parts. Miss one and it guesses, or skips you.

📏 **FACTS**
Size, material, price, specs in plain text

🎯 **FIT**
Who it's for, what it's for, who it's not for

⭐ **PROOF**
Reviews and mentions that back it up

WHAT TO STATE, BY CATEGORY

CATEGORY	BUYER ASKS	PAGE MUST STATE
Coffee	"best beans for espresso under $25"	Roast, origin, tasting notes, brew method
Skincare	"serum for oily skin without fragrance"	Skin type, key actives, %, free-from list
Pet	"food for a senior dog with allergies"	Life stage, protein source, what it excludes
Apparel	"waterproof jacket for hiking in rain"	Rating, weight, fit, use case
Home	"sofa that fits a small apartment"	Exact dimensions, fabric, assembly

4 MISTAKES THAT KEEP YOU OFF THE AI SHELF

1. Specs only in images or size-chart pop-ups — **PUT IN TEXT**
2. Copy that says "premium" and nothing else — **STATE FACTS**
3. Blocking AI crawlers in robots.txt — **ALLOW THEM**
4. Only ever asking AI about your brand name — **ASK LIKE A BUYER**

See which of your products AI recommends, free — **Comment "CHECK"**

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THE WHOLE PICTURE

The AI Shopping Funnel

7

AI isn't a separate channel bolted on the side. It shows up at every stage, from first discovery to the repeat order. Use this to see where your current marketing already covers it and where it doesn't.

WHAT TO TAKE FROM IT

- Discover and Intent are where AI recommendations matter most.
- Each stage has its own KPIs. Track the ones on the left.
- Loyalty feeds discovery: reviews that name a use case are what AI reads next.

> **Do this week:** Pick one KPI per stage and write down today's number, so you have a baseline.

The sheet is on the next page →

The *AI Shopping* Funnel

Updated for 2027

↓ ↓ ↓

DISCOVER

Get named by AI and by people

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
- ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google AI Mode
- TikTok, YouTube, Reddit

KPIS:
- Products named by AI
- Share of voice in your category

STRATEGY:
- Answer category questions on product and collection pages
- Get into "best of" roundups
- Let AI crawlers read your store

CONSIDER

Win the comparison

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
- "X vs Y" questions to AI
- YouTube reviews, Reddit threads

KPIS:
- Position in AI answers
- Review count, branded searches

STRATEGY:
- Comparison pages against the rivals AI names
- Reviews that mention the use case
- A specs table buyers can compare

INTENT

Match the exact question

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
- "Best X for Y under $Z" prompts
- Google Shopping, Merchant Center

KPIS:
- Visibility on buyer questions
- Product page visits, add-to-carts

STRATEGY:
- Size, material, price and use in plain text
- Clean product feed
- Product FAQs

CONVERT

Close the decided shopper

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
- Product page and checkout
- Checkout inside AI assistants

KPIS:
- Conversion rate from AI visits
- Cart abandonment

STRATEGY:
- Price, stock and shipping above the fold
- Fast checkout, no pop-ups
- Returns policy in plain sight

LOYALTY

Get asked for by name

WHERE IT HAPPENS:
- Email, SMS, reviews
- Communities and referrals

KPIS:
- Repeat purchase rate
- Reviews written

STRATEGY:
- Ask for reviews that name the use case
- Post-purchase FAQs and care guides
- Referral offer

See where your products stand at stage 1, free — **Comment "CHECK"**

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SCORECARD

Is your store *AI-ready?* 8

12 checks, one point each. Takes about 10 minutes.

READ

- [ ] robots.txt doesn't block OAI-SearchBot or PerplexityBot
- [ ] Price, size and stock are in the page text, not only in images
- [ ] Product structured data passes Google's Rich Results Test

ANSWER

- [ ] Your best seller's page states material, size and what it's for
- [ ] The page answers the 3 questions buyers ask before buying
- [ ] It says who it's for, and who it's not for

TALKED ABOUT

- [ ] Reviews on your product pages
- [ ] Mentioned in at least one “best [product]” article or Reddit thread
- [ ] Listed in Google Merchant Center

CHECKED

- [ ] You've asked ChatGPT your buyer's question this month
- [ ] You know which competitor product it picks instead
- [ ] Someone on your team owns this

0–4
AI probably can't read or understand you

5–8
Visible, but rarely the one picked

9–12
Ahead of most stores

WHEN YOU HAVE MORE THAN A FEW PRODUCTS

Doing this by hand works for *one product*

Produkto does it for your whole catalog. Paste your store URL and it asks AI assistants the questions your buyers ask, every day, then shows which of your products get recommended, where they rank, and which competitors get picked instead.

Its Catalog Optimization Agent finds the details buyers ask about that your product pages leave out, and drafts the fixes. You review and approve every one before anything changes on your store.

Free check of your store	Reply to the post, or email kelian@getprodukto.com
Book a demo	getprodukto.com